The EU's Arctic shipping mirage

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By JORDYN DAHL with TOMMASO LECCA and MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK — A new expert r

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

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SNEAK PEEK

— A new expert report argues that the Arctic shipping route is still not a good Plan B .

— Over 20 planes were targeted by bomb threats in Europe, forcing flight diversions, some involving fighter jet escorts.

— The German car lobby is urging the Commission to suspend the utility factor immediately.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us @tommylecca , @jordyndahl and @martsapio .

Mark your calendars: Our weekly mobility calendar landed in your inbox on Thursday. You can also go online to export and plan your week or suggest your own event.

DRIVING THE DAY

THE ARCTIC SHIPPING MIRAGE: The EU's new Arctic strategy talks up northern sea routes for trade and economic security, but a new report by European experts argues the Arctic is far from ready as a backup to Suez or the Red Sea, although some Chinese ships are using the route.

Not a plan B: Researchers from Systemiq, the University of Oxford Environmental Change Institute and the Clingendael Institute said that even during prolonged disruptions, shipping companies would still be more likely to divert around the Cape of Good Hope than head north. The Arctic lacks the ports, refueling infrastructure, rescue capacity and predictable conditions carriers need to plan regular services.

Why Brussels cares: The EU strategy says emerging shipping routes could reshape global trade and promises a foresight study on new maritime corridors, traffic flows, fleet needs and ice conditions. It also wants rail links and other infrastructure connecting the Arctic to European markets.

Cold economics: But the report suggests less than 0.2% of global trade by value would shift to Arctic routes by 2050. Total cost savings for industry based on this re-routing come to about $95 million.

Experts said the figure is likely an upper bound once the realities of container networks, insurance and infrastructure are taken into account.

Russia problem: The route with the greatest commercial potential runs along Russia's northern coast, meaning Western operators would face dependence on Russian infrastructure, sanctions and political risk. And the geopolitical risk is still there: "Every Arctic route between the Pacific and Europe must pass through the Bering Strait, a single corridor barely 50 miles wide and shared by Russia and the United States," said the report.

Their advice to Brussels: The experts urge the EU not to lock itself into expensive new shipping infrastructure too early, particularly in the central Arctic Ocean, and instead prioritize precaution, safety standards, research and environmental protection while the Commission carries out its foresight study.

But China is already there: Yet, while the commercial case remains limited today, Beijing is on the route, gaining real-world experience for the future. As Arctic researcher Malte Humpert told Martina last year when Chinese regular transit started, the point is not that the route will replace Suez tomorrow, but that continued ice loss could make it increasingly useful over the next few decades. All eight advertised China-Europe sailings on the Northern Sea Route ran this year, with the fastest reaching Europe in about three weeks.

AVIATION

BOMB THREATS DISRUPT EUROPEAN AIR TRAFFIC: Over 20 aircraft were targeted by bomb threats in Europe on Thursday, forcing flight diversions, some involving fighter jet escorts, airport searches, aircraft changes before departure and lengthy delays. At least seven planes were targeted by similar threats earlier this week. Tommaso has more .

What's behind the threats? "We don't have information yet whether this is a cyberattack," Transport Commissioner Apostolos Tzitzikostas said in a press conference Thursday. "It is too early to draw conclusions on whether the reported incidents are linked. National investigations remain ongoing," he added, noting that an EU-level information-sharing mechanism for aviation security had been activated.

EASA's role: The EU Aviation Safety Agency told Tommaso that its role is limited, however, it does have rules on how to respond to incidents. "For example, EASA's Air Operations Rules address how airlines prepare their crews to respond to security threats," said Janet Northcote, EASA's spokesperson. "This includes provisions for crew training on handling potential bomb threats, ensuring that crews are prepared to respond appropriately should such situations arise."

Air traffic effects: EASA is also monitoring the impact of flight diversions caused by the bomb threats. They are "a disturbance to a system designed for predictability and efficiency, and lead to increased workload for pilots, air traffic controllers and airports," Northcote said. "As these staff have all been trained to cope with such unexpected developments, the immediate safety threat from individual hoax threats is low," she added. But "the higher number of diversions places an additional strain on the system."

KLM CUTS WORKFORCE: Dutch carrier KLM, part of the Air France-KLM group, announced Thursday that it would cut almost 15% of its workforce, or 5,000 positions, which "have been or will be reorganized, with the work carried out differently." The restructuring is part of a broader plan to cut costs and "strengthen its position and keep the Netherlands connected to the world."

Grab a calculator: The airline said that, thanks to “productivity improvements,” the plan will result in a net reduction of only 1,000 positions. Already this year, “the work associated with 1,250 positions at KLM Catering Services has been carried out in partnership with gategroup,” KLM said. “An estimated 800 positions in Ground Services will involve work that will be transferred to external providers in the future.” In addition, “2,000 positions, including 1,500 at customer contact center Cygnific, will be transferred to Air France-KLM.”

The outlook: CEO Marjan Rintel said that “KLM’s future is not guaranteed” amid global instability, high fuel prices and growing pressure on the industry.

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CARS

CAR LOBBY URGES ACTION ON UTILITY FACTOR: The German car lobby VDA is sending a letter to Commission President Ursula von der Leyen today, urging the executive to take immediate action to suspend the utility factor, according to a copy of the letter seen by our colleague Romanus Otte.

Reminder: The utility factor is used to calculate the emissions from plug-in hybrids by measuring how often the vehicle is driven on the electric motor rather than the internal combustion engine. The current calculation uses lab data. The Commission plans to base the factor on real-world data, which suggest drivers use the combustion engine more often.

Status update: The factor has been incorporated into the Automotive Package as part of the omnibus, and the leading committees in Parliament approved a compromise earlier this week that would freeze the utility factor until January 2030. A similar proposal from the Irish Council presidency would do the same. (Jordyn has that scoop here .)

Why now: The new calculation takes effect on Nov. 27. Even if the institutions agree on freezing the factor in trilogue negotiations, it would come too late, the letter states. The VDA wants von der Leyen to intervene before then and suspend the mechanism. It also wants the factor suspended for five years instead of the proposed three years that is part of Parliament’s draft position.

CO2 STANDARDS IGNORE DRIVERS: Current negotiations on changing the EU’s car emissions rules doesn’t focus enough on ensuring people can buy affordable TVs, said Diogo Pinto, director general for FIA Region I, a driver’s organization, speaking at Thursday’s mobility-focused panel at the Public Affairs Summit. “The debate has been monopolized by either the interests of the industry or the need for protecting the environment,” he said, adding that drivers are interested in EVs, but there is an affordability problem as many electric cars are still quite expensive, and that car owners need price certainty. “If they trust that when they cross the borders they can still charge [their cars] and understand the pricing of the charging system, that when there is a repair needed what is going to cost them and when they want to sell the vehicle after a couple of years, what is going to be the value of this asset.”

The benefits of the EV transition: Emissions reduction targets help make EVs more affordable, argued Anna Krajinska, senior director for vehicles at green NGO Transport & Environment. Being forced to

meet the bloc's emissions cuts makes EU automakers more competitive in non-European markets and also helps them fend off the rising presence of Chinese carmakers in the EU.

It's us or them: The question is no longer whether consumers will buy EVs but which brands they'll buy, said Céline Domecq, head of public affairs for Volvo Cars. "If the Chinese have affordable, attractive EVs on the market, that's what people will buy."

DUTCH FUEL PRICE TRANSPARENCY: The Dutch competition authority wants gas stations to share real-time fuel prices for free with comparison websites and navigation apps to help drivers find cheaper fuel and boost competition, reports our colleague Aude van den Hove. The antitrust agency estimates that even a one-cent-per-liter price reduction could save consumers €59 million annually.

PIT STOPS

From us : The Court of Justice of the EU on Thursday overturned two lower court rulings that had sided with Ryanair on state aid granted to KLM and Condor during the Covid pandemic.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

EU staffing crunch hinders response to Chinese trade pressure
The European Commission is finding it hard to keep up with demands to investigate unfair practices.
By Koen Verhelst · Nov 06, 2026, 06:00 am Europe/Brussels CET

Bomb threats target at least 22 more European flights
Aircraft across Europe were diverted after a spate of security threats.
By Tommaso Lecca · Nov 05, 2026, 12:21 pm Europe/Brussels CET

EU top court overturns two Ryanair victories in state aid cases
By Tommaso Lecca · Nov 05, 2026, 11:15 am Europe/Brussels CET

Irish Council presidency proposes stricter emissions target for automakers
By Jordyn Dahl · Nov 05, 2026, 11:02 am Europe/Brussels CET

Weekly Calendar

Here's a selection of upcoming key events, find the complete Week Ahead online.

The US Midterms: What Changes for Europe?
Nov 9, 2026, 12:30 PM - 2:00 pm

Eurocontrol 'European Network of U-space Stakeholders Meeting'
Nov 9, 2026, 2:50 PM · Brussels, BE

Council Working Party on Land Transport
Nov 10, 2026 · Brussels, BE

POLITICO Pro Petit-Déjeuner – Entre COP et budget, l'automne s'annonce chargé
Nov 10, 2026, 8:15 AM - 10:00 am

European Parliament plenary session

Nov 11, 2026 - Nov 12, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Coreper I
Nov 11, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Coreper II
Nov 11, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Council Working Party on Space
Nov 11, 2026 · Brussels, BE

European Political Community meeting
Nov 12, 2026 · Dublin, IE

Council Working Party on Transport — Intermodal Questions and Networks
Nov 12, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Council Working Party for Schengen Matters
Nov 12, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Eurocontrol 'FLY AI Event'
Nov 12, 2026, 8:00 AM - Nov 13, 2026, 8:00 AM · Brétigny-sur-Orge, FR

Pro Roundtable – Mobility
Nov 12, 2026, 8:15 AM - 9:45 am

Council informal meeting of heads of state or government
Nov 13, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Coreper I
Nov 13, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Council Working Party for Schengen Matters
Nov 13, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Executive Transatlantic Exchange
Nov 14, 2026, 1:00 PM - 4:00 pm

IATA 'Schedule Data Exchange Program Forum'
Nov 16, 2026 · Budapest, HU

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